What is a decomposer?

BACKGROUND

nutrients (say 'nu-tree-ants') – substances that give animals and plants the energy essential for growth and life

A decomposer is a living thing that works to break down **organic** materials into smaller parts. For example, a decomposer breaks down fruit on a forest floor by making it rot or decay. The decomposer absorbs the nutrients from the remains and also releases some nutrients into the soil.

Fungi and moulds are decomposers. They decompose plant waste, including vegetables. Some small organisms from the animal kingdom are also decomposers, including worms, slugs, millipedes and termites, which break down logs and sticks. Other decomposers, like maggots and flies, help to break down dead animal carcasses (bodies). Dung (animal droppings) is broken down by dung flies and beetles. Microorganisms, including various bacteria, break down all kinds of substances, including milk, eggs and meat products.

☞ **1** Circle six things that are classified as decomposers.

termite	bacteria	mould	toadstool
maggot	rabbit	worm	eagle

2 Write these words into the spaces below. The lines break them into syllables.

decompose __ __ / __ __ __ / __ __ __ __

decomposers __ __ / __ __ __ / __ __ __ / __ __ __

decomposition __ __ / __ __ __ / __ __ __ / __ / __ __ __ __

3 Complete this passage by filling in the missing vowels (a, e, i, o, u).

D __ c __ mp __ s __ rs break down dead __ rg __ n __ sms into sm __ ller parts. Leaf litter, animal d __ ng, bodies of d __ __ d creatures and dead pl __ nts all d __ c __ mp __ s __. After decomposition, the n __ trients that were contained in the decayed organisms return to the s __ __ l. In this way, they are r __ cycl __ d. Nutrients in the soil are then taken up into y __ __ ng plants and __ n __ mals eat the plants. The cycle of life and death begins again.

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What is a decomposer? CONT'D

4 Match the decomposer with the material it works on by drawing a line between the two.

Material	Decomposer
a) leaf litter	dung flies
b) logs	slugs
c) dung	lactobacteria
d) fruit	maggots
e) dead animal carcass	termites
f) vegetables	fungi
g) milk	fruit flies

In an ecosystem, the substances contained in food are cycled through the system by producers, consumers and decomposers – although the substances change their form. The main chemical substance in food and living things is called **carbon**.

5 Unscramble the words in brackets to complete the passage.

Dead leaves, grass and (ruitf) _____ and (egetablesv) _____ begin to (ecayd) _____ and become slimy and (mellys) _____ on the ground. (ecomposersD) _____ act on these items in the (armw) _____, (arkd) _____ soil. These decomposers include (acteriab) _____, (ouldm) _____ and (ungif) _____. They (reakb) _____ down the material and the (utrientsn) _____ return to the soil. Nutrients are made of (hemicalsc) _____ that living things need to eat and (bsorba) _____ to stay healthy.

(anureM) _____ and (ottenr) _____ (eatm) _____ from the (arcassesc) _____ of dead animals are another source of food for decomposers. They break these down and the (arbonc) _____ cycle continues in the (cosysteme) _____.

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